

Culture & Corrida

Different strokes for different folks — a B1 conversation lesson

Customs that look strange from the outside: bullfighting in Spain, Black Friday in the USA, the Czech Easter whip. What makes a tradition yours — and can it be part of who you are and still be wrong?

READING	A three-paragraph text on the corrido, with comprehension questions
VOCABULARY	shocking, cruel, to be used to, custom, ritual, national identity, ban, outsider
VIDEO	Six silent clips, one QR code each — students guess the country
GRAMMAR	AT / ON / IN with holidays and dates, plus a common-mistakes table
SPEAKING	Guess the Tradition and Just a Minute, on a bank of 25 world traditions
DISCUSSION	Questions in three tiers, ending on the one that starts the real argument
HANDOUT	A one-page student sheet: vocabulary, phrases and the tradition bank

Print it or share your screen. Works 1-to-1 and in small groups.

A heads-up: the corrido section touches animal cruelty. Read the room.

Free to use in your own teaching. Please don't resell it or share it as your own.

Culture & Corrida — *Different Strokes for Different Folks*

Level	B1
Activity	Speaking

Opening Question

Ask the class

"Think about a tradition or custom from your family or your country. Is there anything you do that a foreigner might find strange or surprising?"

Follow-up: "What about food — is there something from your country that foreigners always react to?"

Story

Read this to the class

Paragraph 1. In Spain, *la corrida* — bullfighting — is more than just a sport. For many Spaniards, it is part of their national identity, a tradition that goes back hundreds of years. Every spring and summer, crowds fill the arenas to watch matadors face bulls in a dramatic and very dangerous ritual.

Paragraph 2. But not everyone agrees. Animal rights groups argue that *la corrida* is cruel and should be banned. Several Spanish regions have already made it illegal. And when Spanish people travel abroad and see what other countries do for fun — like Finland's wife-carrying races, or people in England throwing themselves down a hill after a rolling cheese — they might feel just as surprised as many visitors feel about the corrida.

Paragraph 3. Every culture has customs that seem perfectly normal from the inside but very strange from the outside. Día de los Muertos in Mexico, Black Friday shopping chaos in the USA, wife carrying in Finland, La Tomatina tomato festival in Spain — all of these are celebrated by millions of people. But to an outsider, they might look very odd indeed.

Comprehension check

1. What is la corrida, and where does it happen?
2. Why do some people want to ban it?
3. According to the text, why might Spanish people be surprised by customs in other countries?
4. Can you name one other cultural custom mentioned in the passage?

Vocabulary

English	Simple definition	Example sentence
shocking ★	surprising in a bad or uncomfortable way	I found the images from the bullfight very shocking.
cruel	causing pain or suffering on purpose	Some people think hunting is cruel.
to look strange	to seem unusual or odd to someone	Some local traditions look strange to foreign visitors.
to be used to	to be familiar with something because you do it often	I am used to drinking tea in the afternoon.
offensive ★	making someone feel upset or angry because it goes against their values	Some people find the festival offensive.

English	Simple definition	Example sentence
tradition ★	something people do every year because their parents did it too	Giving gifts at Christmas is a popular tradition.
custom ★	a usual way of behaving in a community	In Japan, it is a custom to take off your shoes indoors.
ritual	a set of actions always done in the same order, often for a ceremony	The bullfight follows a very specific ritual.
national identity	the feeling of belonging to a particular country and its culture	La corrida is part of Spain's national identity for many people.
ban ★	to say officially that something is not allowed	Several regions in Spain have banned bullfighting.
outsider	someone who is not part of a group or culture	As an outsider, I found the festival very confusing.

The Videos — Watch, React, Guess

These clips have no narration. Play each one **on mute** — the traditions speak for themselves. Let students watch, react out loud, and guess before you say anything.

While you watch, ask:

Guess the country: What do you see? What country is it from? Does it look fun, strange, dangerous, beautiful, or crazy? Would you try it — why or why not?

Use the present continuous: What is happening? What are they doing? How are they feeling?



[Corrida — bullfighting](#)

[A matador kneels in the sand and waits for the bull. Seville, Spain.](#)

[Q: How would you feel kneeling in front of the bull? Is this brave, crazy, or cruel?](#)



[Día de los Muertos — Day of the Dead](#)

[People paint their faces as skeletons and parade through Mexico City.](#)

[Q: Is this a sad tradition or a happy one? How do people remember the dead where you live?](#)



[Black Friday](#)

[Crowds push and fight over cheap products the day after Thanksgiving, USA.](#)

[Q: What are these people feeling? Have you ever seen shopping get this crazy?](#)



[Wife Carrying](#)

[One person carries another through an obstacle course. Finland.](#)

[Q: What do you think the winner's prize is? Would you and a friend try this?](#)



[La Tomatina](#)

[Thousands throw tomatoes at each other in the streets of Buñol, Spain.](#)

[Q: Is this a waste of food or harmless fun? Would you jump in?](#)



[Cheese Rolling](#)

[People throw themselves down a very steep hill chasing a wheel of cheese. England.](#)

[Q: Why do you think anyone does this? What is the strangest “sport” you know?](#)

Discussion Questions

● Starter 1

Have you ever seen or done something from another culture that looked very strange to you at first?

Follow-up: Did your opinion change afterwards?

● Starter 2

Do you think people from very different cultures can ever fully understand each other's traditions?

Follow-up: How would you explain one of your own country's customs to a foreign visitor?

● Starter 3

Do you know about any of these festivals — La Tomatina, Wife Carrying, Día de los Muertos, Black Friday? Which one seems strangest to you?

Follow-up: Would you ever want to try any of them?

● Main 4

La corrida is a tradition for many Spaniards but is seen as cruel by many people outside Spain. Can a tradition be part of national identity AND be wrong at the same time?

Follow-up: Can you think of any custom, anywhere, where people disagree about whether it is acceptable?

● Main 5

Is it a good thing when a country adopts a foreign tradition like Black Friday?

Follow-up: Which is stranger — throwing tomatoes at La Tomatina, or fighting through a crowd on Black Friday?

● Main 6

Should some traditions be banned?

● Deeper 7 — optional

Imagine an alien visits Earth and watches humans celebrate La Tomatina, corrida, Easter, and Black Friday all in one week. What would it think about us?

GIVING YOUR OPINION

Personally, I think... • In my opinion... • To be honest... • I find it hard to understand why...

AGREEING / DISAGREEING

I completely agree. • That's a good point, but... • I see it differently. • I'm not sure about that.

TALKING ABOUT CULTURAL DIFFERENCES

From the outside, it looks... • I'm used to it, so for me it's normal. • Different strokes for different folks.

Grammar — Prepositions of Time: AT / ON / IN

Prep.	Use it for...	Examples from today's topic
AT	Holidays & festivals (at Easter, at Christmas, at New Year)	At Easter, people paint eggs. / At La Tomatina, people throw tomatoes.
ON	Specific days & dates (on Monday, on	On Black Friday, shops have huge sales. / On the day of the

Prep.	Use it for...	Examples from today's topic
	Christmas Day, on 1st November)	corrida, the arena is full.
IN	Months / years / seasons (in November, in 2020, in spring)	Día de los Muertos is celebrated in November. / Wife Carrying happens in summer.
IN	Countries / cities (in Spain, in Finland, in Mexico)	In Spain, there are still many bullfighting arenas. / La Tomatina is held in Buñol, in Spain.

Practice sentences — students complete out loud

1. "Wife Carrying is a competition held ____ a northern country. It usually takes place ____ summer."
2. "____ Easter, many people travel to see family. ____ some countries, this is a very old tradition."
3. "Black Friday started ____ one country. Shops have big sales ____ the last Friday ____ November."

Correct the mistake

 Common mistake	 Correction + explanation
"on Easter" / "on Christmas"	at Easter / at Christmas. Holidays and festivals take AT in English, not ON.
"in Friday" / "in Monday"	on Friday / on Monday. Days of the week always use ON, not IN.
"It is tradition in Spain." (missing article)	It is a tradition in Spain. Singular countable nouns need an article (a/the).
"They are used to do it." (wrong form)	They are used to doing it. After “used to” (= familiar with), use the -ing form, not the infinitive.
"For me is normal." (missing subject)	For me, it is normal. English always needs a subject — a sentence cannot start with the predicate.

Speaking Activities

Guess the Tradition.

Choose one tradition from the bank below. Pretend you *are* that tradition. The others ask questions and guess who you are.

Just a Minute.

Choose one tradition from the bank. Prepare a one-minute talk about it. While one student speaks, the others listen and write down one or two follow-up questions.

Tradition Bank — pick a card for the activities above

Name	When	Keywords	Country / region	Simple description
Christmas	24–25 December	tree, presents, family dinner, lights	Many countries	People spend time with family, decorate a tree, give presents, and often eat a special dinner.
Halloween	31 October	costumes, pumpkins, ghosts, trick-or-treating	USA / UK / many	People wear scary or funny costumes, decorate pumpkins, and children ask for sweets.
Easter	March / April	eggs, rabbits, spring, church, family	Many countries	People celebrate spring, new life, and for Christians, the resurrection of Jesus.
New Year's Eve	31 December	fireworks, countdown, party, midnight	Worldwide	People celebrate the last night of the year with parties, fireworks, and a countdown to midnight.
Valentine's Day	14 February	love, flowers, chocolate, couples	Many countries	People celebrate love and often give flowers, chocolate, cards, or gifts to someone special.
Carnival	February / March	costumes, masks, dancing, parade, music	Brazil / Venice / many	People wear colorful costumes or masks, dance in the streets, and enjoy big parades before Lent.
Lunar New Year	January / February	dragon, red color, fireworks, family, luck	China / East Asia	Families celebrate the new year on the lunar calendar with food, red decorations, and wishes for luck.
Thanksgiving	October / November	turkey, family dinner, gratitude, harvest	USA / Canada	Families meet for a big meal, often with turkey, and talk about what they are thankful for.
Día de los Muertos	1–2 November	skulls, flowers, ancestors, candles, graves	Mexico	People remember family members who have died with colorful decorations, flowers, food, and candles.
Holi	February / March	colors, powder, dancing, spring, joy	India	People celebrate spring by throwing colorful powder, dancing, singing, and spending time together.
Diwali	October / November	lights, candles, fireworks, good over evil	India	People celebrate the victory of light over darkness by lighting candles, decorating homes, and watching fireworks.
Oktoberfest	September / October	beer, tents, traditional clothes, music	Germany	People meet in large tents, drink beer, eat traditional food, wear traditional clothes, and listen to music.
La Tomatina	Last Wed. of August	tomatoes, food fight, red, streets, fun	Spain	People gather in the streets and throw tomatoes at each other in a huge, messy food fight.
Bullfighting / La corrida	Mainly spring / summer	bull, matador, arena, danger, controversy	Spain	A matador faces a bull in an arena. Some people see it as tradition; others think it is cruel.
Running of the Bulls	July	bulls, running, streets, danger, adrenaline	Spain	People run through narrow streets while bulls run behind them. It is famous, exciting, and dangerous.
Wife Carrying	Summer	race, obstacle course, carrying, couples	Finland	One person carries another through an obstacle course in a funny race that tests speed, strength, and teamwork.
Cheese Rolling	Late May	cheese, hill, running,	England	People run down a very steep hill

Name	When	Keywords	Country / region	Simple description
		falling, race		chasing a round cheese, often falling on the way down.
Songkran	13–15 April	water fight, New Year, streets, cleaning	Thailand	People celebrate the Thai New Year with water fights, family visits, and symbolic washing for good luck.
St. Patrick's Day	17 March	green, shamrock, parade, beer	Ireland / USA	People celebrate Irish culture by wearing green, joining parades, and using symbols like shamrocks.
Hanami	March / April	cherry blossoms, picnic, spring, parks	Japan	People go to parks to enjoy cherry blossoms, have picnics, and celebrate the beauty of spring.
Bonfire Night	5 November	fireworks, bonfire, Guy Fawkes, history	UK	People light bonfires and watch fireworks to remember a historical event from British history.
Krampus Night	5 December	scary costumes, devils, children, winter	Austria / C. Europe	People dress as Krampus, a scary devil-like figure who traditionally scares naughty children.
Easter Whipping	Easter Monday	willow sticks, eggs, spring, playful	Czech Rep. / Slovakia	Boys and men lightly tap girls and women with decorated willow sticks. It is symbolic and playful, but outsiders often find it strange.
April Fools' Day	1 April	jokes, pranks, fake stories, laughter	Many countries	People play jokes on friends, family, or the public — but the jokes should be harmless and funny.

Culture & Corrida — Student Sheet

Different strokes for different folks · Level B1 · Keep this in front of you during the lesson.

Key Vocabulary

Word	Meaning	Word	Meaning
shocking ★	surprising in a bad or uncomfortable way	custom ★	a usual way of behaving in a community
cruel	causing pain or suffering on purpose	ritual	actions always done in the same order
to look strange	to seem unusual or odd to someone	national identity	the feeling of belonging to a country & its culture
to be used to	to be familiar with something you do often	ban ★	to say officially something is not allowed
offensive ★	upsetting because it goes against someone's values	outsider	someone not part of a group or culture
tradition ★	something people do every year, passed down	arena	a large space where an event or show happens

Useful Phrases for the Discussion

GIVING YOUR OPINION

Personally, I think... · In my opinion... · To be honest... · I find it hard to understand why...

AGREEING / DISAGREEING

I completely agree. · That's a good point, but... · I see it differently. · I'm not sure about that.

TALKING ABOUT CULTURAL DIFFERENCES

From the outside, it looks... · I'm used to it, so for me it's normal. · Different strokes for different folks.

Tradition Bank

pick one for "Guess the Tradition" or "Just a Minute"

- Christmas** — many countries

New Year's Eve — worldwide

Lunar New Year — China / East Asia

Holi — India

La Tomatina — Spain

Wife Carrying — Finland

St. Patrick's Day — Ireland

Krampus Night — Austria
- Halloween** — USA / UK

Valentine's Day — many countries

Thanksgiving — USA / Canada

Diwali — India

La corrida — Spain

Cheese Rolling — England

Hanami — Japan

Easter Whipping — Czech Rep. / Slovakia
- Easter** — many countries

Carnival — Brazil / Venice

Día de los Muertos — Mexico

Oktoberfest — Germany

Running of the Bulls — Spain

Songkran — Thailand

Bonfire Night — UK

April Fools' Day — many countries

If this worked in your class

I'm Ondra, an English teacher in the Czech Republic. I teach about thirty classes a week, nearly all adults, and I write these lessons for my own classes first — then tidy them up so other teachers can use them.

There are twenty more: grammar worksheets, speaking activities, business English, current-events lessons and no-prep games, A1 to C1. Every one comes with a teacher's guide and an answer key.

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